regime. They supported the Taliban in its battles against the UF, but also became its Achilles Heel.[173]

Secondly, though there was a decisive regional consensus against the Taliban regime, Washington decided to pursue limited unofficial engagement with the Taliban (despite finding its ideology repugnant). This was the kind of engagement that conciliators in India had advocated throughout. However, such engagement by the US was inadequate for strengthening the hands of the conciliators in India to change policy course. Instead it was seen mostly as a suspicious American ploy to safeguard its energy interests at the detriment of regional security. It is in this context that the partisan-dominated India continued to chastise the US for abetting the rise of the Taliban. The 1998 East Africa bombings, which coincided with the nuclearisation of South Asia, changed these dynamics. India found it imperative to get the US on board on the nuclear debate (in order to lift the sanctions that came with the Pokharan tests), but also saw an opportunity to peddle US anxieties on terrorism. Instead of following Washington's half-hearted advocacy of engaging with the Taliban, India actively influenced US perceptions on cross-border militancy and the illegitimacy of the Taliban that supported global terrorism. September 11 was a watershed moment that decisively shifted US policy attitudes along partisan lines. However, after the tumult of the initial weeks after the 9/11 attacks, the Bonn Conference underlined the limits of India's partisan advocacy on Afghanistan. Having put all its eggs in the UF basket, India was disappointed when the US appointed Karzai as the interim president, allowing the conciliators a comeback. Karzai's rise, despite leaving a bad taste among Indian policymakers, was a blessing for both the partisans and conciliators. Legitimised by the international community, Karzai started talks with Pakistan to the conciliators' delight. But soon after, as these talks failed to reap results on the ground and the Taliban made a comeback, much to the partisans' pleasure, Karzai turned unimaginably hostile towards Pakistan.